

**Medford Public Schools
Medford, Massachusetts**

**Medford School Committee
Committee of the Whole
October 29, 2013**

The meeting was called to order at 7:00 p.m. in the Superintendent 's Conference Room at Medford High School by Chairperson John Falco.

Members present: Ann Marie Cugno, Erin DiBenedetto, John Falco, Robert E. Skerry Jr., and Paulette Van der Kloot. (5 present, 2 absent)

Also present: Superintendent Roy E. Belson, Pupil Services Director Kathy Medaglio, Curtis Program Director Anthony Volpe, Consultant James Earley, Sped Clinical Supervisor Jeff Lappin, and Curtis-Tufts faculty members Lance Yodzio, David DiMattia, Paul Hurd, Justin Moyer and Mary Monteiro.

All rose to salute the Flag.

Chairperson Falco stated that the purpose of the meeting is to review the Curtis-Tufts report written by Dr. James Earley and discuss the finding.

Chairperson Falco called upon the Superintendent to introduce the report and Dr. Earley.

The Superintendent explained the reasons why the report was commissioned. The Curtis-Tufts has helped many students over the years, but there are new standards and expectations that are not being met consistent with the need of our students. Also enrollment is way down and the current approach to students needs to be revised. While the program is currently approved by the state, there is a strong feeling that approval could be withdrawn in the future. Also the program with its current enrollment is not as financially advantageous as in the past.

The Superintendent said that Walker Partnerships was the ideal group to review the Curtis-Tufts. Walker Partnerships has worked with many alternative programs over the years and operates its own successful model in Needham. Also Dr. James Early is a former Sped Director and Superintendent of the Watertown Public Schools. In prior years he worked closely with the Curtis-Tufts and sent students to the program.

Dr. Early addressed the group and used a PowerPoint visual presentation to summarize his report (see attached). The report contains 32 findings and makes 14 recommendations distributed among 6 sections.

Dr. Earley stated that the Medford Public Schools has been proactive and has implemented several of his recommendations as the school year began. The program now has a new female counselor, expanded nursing services, and additional instructional paraprofessional support.

A meeting was held at the opening of school with Walker and the Curtis-Tufts faculty to review the mission statement and to discuss the operational concerns of the program. The Superintendent and the Pupil Services Director were there for most of the meeting as active participants with the faculty and the Walker group.

School Committee members stated that the report was a thorough one and gave them real ideas to work with as they addressed the Curtis-Tufts. Pupil Services Director Kathy Medaglio agreed with the assessment of the report.

The following represents the major points covered during the meeting:

- The beginning of the day has been tightened up. The forty minute open period has been reduced to ten minutes. While there is still tardiness, it is better than last year.
- The current disciplinary point system is not effective at this level. The program must move from a behavior management model. Process change can be difficult. However, staff understands the difference and is prepared to move forward.
- Each year the program must adapt to meet the needs of the specific students assigned to the school. This year the students are better and more attuned to the requirements of the curriculum. Staff has ownership of the curriculum program. This year there will be more initiatives with department directors and the high school administration.
- Enrollment is partially a function of program credibility. This is especially true of students coming from other communities. Also parents must believe that the Curtis-Tufts is a valid option for their youth and not just an alternative to the high school.
- Parental involvement is not easy to obtain at the Curtis-Tufts. Many parents have work and family issues that mitigate against their involvement.
- There is a need for more supervised work placement programming. We have some work study. Our goal must be to prepare these students for a return to their community in a productive role after graduation.
- There needs to be greater interaction with the high school. Movement from Curtis to high school and voc must be further developed.
- The referral process must be more formalized. There have been too many referrals in previous years where the student is not a fit for the program and/or the program was not prepared to receive the student.
- Jeff Lappin in his new role will be facilitating more clinical communication between the Curtis and other related district services.
- The furniture in the Curtis-Tufts facility needs to be updated. There are other building repairs as well.

- We must work to improve the program so that we can have credibility both inside and outside of the district.

Walker will continue to work with the program. The Curtis-Tufts has strong potential but it must make changes to be effective going forward. It must stress therapeutic intervention over monolithic behavior management strategies.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno the meeting was adjourned at 9:28 p.m.

Respectfully submitted,

John Falco, Chairperson